Cross-Team Retro

Reflect across teams at the end of a period: what worked, what didn't, and one system problem to fix together.

Coordinate Teams · Inspect & Adapt (SAFe) · Joint Retrospective · Fix the System

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

LEGEND

- Green = Went well
- Pink = Problem
- Blue = Idea
- Dot = Vote

1 What We Set Out to Do

BRING THE SHARED OBJECTIVES AND THE DATA

SHARED OBJECTIVE	PLANNED VALUE	ACHIEVED	WHAT WE LEARNED
Make the weekly shop effortless	9	8	Reorder landed; substitutes slipped an iteration
Make checkout quick and trustworthy	8	6	Wallet payments waited on the Wallet API

2 Went Well Across Teams

KEEP DOING

Where did teams help each other?

- Self-service deploys freed up Checkout
- Shared on-call rota
- Payments paired with Basket on billing
- Daily sync caught blockers early

3 Cross-Team Problems

DOT-VOTE THE BIGGEST

Where did work wait between teams?

- Waiting on the Stock API ●●●●●
- The Payments sign-off queue ●●●
- Staging kept going down ●●
- The campaign date changed late ●

4 Ideas

FOR ANY TEAM TO TRY

What would make next period smoother?

- Mocks and contracts so teams don't wait
- Read access instead of new APIs
- One owner for the test environment
- Map dependencies before big-room planning

5 Solve the Top Problem

IN MIXED-TEAM GROUPS

Top problem (most dots): waiting on the Stock API

Why 1? Warehouse had it as a low priority

Why 2? They didn't know our date

Why 3? Dependencies weren't raised at planning

Why 4? Nobody sees who needs what, and when

Root cause: dependencies are agreed late, team to team

IMPROVEMENT	TEAMS INVOLVED	OWNER
Dependency map at every big-room planning	all five	Tom
Warehouse joins the cross-team sync	Basket, Warehouse	Sam
Contract tests for the Stock API	Basket, Warehouse	Alex

6 Follow Through

INTO THE NEXT PLANNING

- [x] Improvements added to the next cross-team plan
- [x] Each improvement has an owner
- [ ] Teams' own retros have the same themes?
- [x] Progress checked at the cross-team sync

We'll measure success by: blocked days, 9 → 3 an iteration

Next cross-team retro: end of Q3

"What got in the way between teams, not within them?"

"What one change would help every team next period?"

© 2026 Eric Parker · CC BY 4.0 · eparker71.github.io/agile-ways-of-working